

Twttrovrkill

Sometimes you just wish a pudgy tat would come along and gobble up all those small blue birds tweeting away to glory

On a silent night, if you listen hard enough, you can hear it, even if you are far away from any kind of technological contrivance. The cacophony of a million (around four million on the last count actually) small blue birds with yellow beaks, tweeting. No seriously, imagine listening to 80 tweets per second. We could generate a sound clip and let you hear it on our DVD*, but you would never forgive us. That's how active the tweetosphere is. It's more than any man can stand, but the small blue birds in the tweetosphere, who call themselves tweeple, have no intention of stopping. Their sole purpose is to take over the world, 140 characters at a time, and they are finding a lot of innovative ways to do so. From the depths of outer space to the depths of the large intestine, and everything in between, the small blue birds are everywhere.

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The roving tweeters

Five of the many small blue birds are not even human. Hell, they are not even on the planet Earth. One of them is floating around in Earth orbit, three of them are on Mars, and one is on Saturn. These tweeters are robotic probes that update their minions of followers about their activities. The Mars Science Lab (<http://twitter.com/MarsScienceLab>), for example, is one of the better tweeters around, and gives human beings a run for their money – at human relations. Tweeter is a social networking site, and The Mars Science Lab understands the rules of the game. It answers tweeple's questions about outer space, the engineering, about its mission, and responds to praise and criticism. When it is not replying to people, it posts thoughts about itself, like the gem "Soo happy that Wall-E won the Golden Globe!" Ah well. Asimov should have seen this coming. The Mars Lab is a rover waiting to go to Mars. The Mars rovers Spirit and Opportunity (shortened to Oppy), share one Twitter page for some strange reason (<http://twitter.com/MarsRovers>). Oppy is the more active of the two, and has a little more sympathy from the tweeters too. It has faced a lot of issues over the years, and the tweeple never fail to bring up old issues. However, Oppy is not too touchy about such things, and responds

to most questions level-headedly. Including things like having a wheel stuck in Martian soil for five weeks. Poor thing. Both Oppy and Spirit are females, getting a few followers with their wives, using emoticons when necessary. The only problem with this dual-identity is that sometimes you don't know which of the two is tweeting. However, the whole enterprise is not devoid of a scientific undercurrent, and Oppy recently reported a "history of wind and water" on Mars. One of the few tweeters we wish had an extended word limit. Cassini is a very savvy, if a little haughty, tweeter (<http://twitter.com/CassiniSaturn>). Despite the 12,000 odd followers, which is more than many humans can hope for, Cassini follows none. Cassini updates followers with regular images from Saturn, which are pretty staggering to begin with. The more important questions are answered, and Cassini uses hashtags more than all the other rovers and The Mars Science Lab put together. Maybe Cassini is a trend setter, but is nothing compared to Phoenix. Phoenix (<http://twitter.com/marsphoenix>) was the coolest rover to hit alien soil. In her time, she could put the nerdiest geeks set loose on the internet to shame. She found ice (the *WATER* kind), on Mars, and reported it with a tweet that contains the word "woot!" This is image macro material, really, and hell, we'll throw one at you too. Pity paper does not playback GIF files. Phoenix put up polls, answered questions, encouraged students to study science and beamed back videos. In the more boring moments, she just talked about the Martian weather. The overwhelming 40,000-odd followers had no problems whatsoever. Is all the past tense hanging ominously over you? Unfortunately, the Phoenix rover was exploring the cold Martian polar regions, and the solar panels could not keep the

rover powered up. You can tell bright little kiddies who are interested that she is in "sleep mode", which isn't far from the truth. She can be re-activated, but that is unlikely, as the sad truth (bright little kiddies stop reading) is that she is slowly getting entombed in ever growing layers of ice (the *DRY* kind).

A selection of tweeting gadgets

A high-tech "digital creative agency" by the name of Poke, were across the street to a baker. Someone had the bright idea of putting a prototype Wi-Fi adapter lying around in the office to good use. They took it across to the baker, installed it in the oven, and set it up so that every time a batch of fresh goodies came out of the oven, it would be announced in the tweetosphere. The whole setup is in London, but you can have a look at twitter.com/albionsoven. Albion's Oven is the only bakery in the world that currently has this set up, but if you own a bakery and want one, you can try your luck at bakertweet.com.

One of the best things about the web is positive or negative re-enforcement. You let everyone online know of your activities, and you are bound to get some feedback. That is the idea behind tweet-a-watt. The designers basically took a standard meter that records the amount of electricity consumed, and fit it out with a wireless connection. Every user's twitter page will have steady updates of their electricity consumption, and everyone in the tweetosphere will know about it. If any one person's carbon footprint is exceeding normal limits, his or her followers are bound to send a few tweets asking him to cut down. Of course, we're wondering how much electricity would be saved if everyone just stopped tweeting to begin with.

A biomedical engineer by the name of Adam Wilson had a bright idea. Instead of writing it down, he connected a mind reading device to his head, and have it tweet it. The software used is the same grade as that used to treat those with paralysis. The interface is a modified version of experiments that allow those with handicaps to interface with computers. The Twitter account itself is down, but the messages that were posted had horrible spelling errors. Rest assured that such a device is far away, and won't trouble you with yet another endless source of tweets.

The bowel twitter movement

You were waiting for the intestine bit weren't you? We'll indulge you, but just this once, mind you. A few days into Twitter, and any user is bound to discover that you can tweet from your phone. A few days

